but the system gave a solid stability to the picture business. You belonged someplace.

But that all changed after the war. An antitrust suit was brought by a private chain of theaters and as a result the Justice Department issued a series of decrees declaring that the studios could either make pictures or operate theaters—they couldn't do both.

This turned Hollywood inside out overnight. The studios chose to continue producing movies. But no longer could they afford stables of actors and other workers under contract because from now on, they had to make movies purely on the speculation theaters would want to show them.

Because of tax problems, many stars were willing to give up the security of a studio contract and a weekly salary. I was one of them. I was in the ninety-four percent tax bracket, which meant the government took most of what I earned. I'd always thought there was something inherently unfair toward actors in the tax system. I'd seen careers take off like a comet, shine briefly, then burn out almost overnight, but during their brief period of stardom, taxes would have eaten up most of their income and they'd have little left afterward.

Nevertheless, I believe the government's decision to break up the studio system was wrong. It destroyed the stability of the industry under the justification that the studios monopolized the picture business. But they didn't have a monopoly; there was intense competition that worked well for everybody. You had seven companies who were always competing with each other to turn out a better movie than the guy down the street, and if people didn't like a picture, they'd show it by voting with their feet.

Owning the theaters provided a guarantee to the studios that if they guessed wrong on a movie and made it, at least they'd get some of their money back by playing it at their